

E-E-A-T

Not a score, not a ranking factor, and still one of the most useful frameworks Google has published.

Bottom line

Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness is the language Google's human quality raters use, approximated in the algorithm through signals it can actually measure. Trust is the one that matters most, and Experience is the one most sites fail. Both are demonstrable with concrete, cheap changes.

What it is and is not

It is not a score. There is no E-E-A-T number in the algorithm and nothing reports one. Tools that claim to measure your E-E-A-T are selling a proxy they invented.

It is not a ranking factor in the direct sense. It is a quality *concept* that the systems try to approximate.

It is the vocabulary of Google's Search Quality Rater Guidelines, a public document used by human evaluators whose ratings inform algorithm development. That indirect path is exactly why it matters and why it cannot be gamed with a checklist.

Trust is the centre. Google's own framing puts Trustworthiness at the middle, with the other three supporting it. A page can be written by a genuine expert and still fail if the site gives no reason to trust it.

Experience: the one most sites fail

The most recent addition and the hardest to fake. It asks whether the author has **first-hand experience** of the subject.

A page about running a site migration written by someone who has run one contains things nobody who has only read about migrations would write: what broke at 2am, which vendor doc was wrong, how long it actually took versus the estimate.

How to demonstrate it:

- Describe **what actually happened**, including the parts that went badly
- Use **your own numbers, screenshots and artifacts** rather than stock examples
- Name **specific tools and versions** you used

- Say **what you would do differently**
- Include the **exceptions and edge cases** you only find by doing the thing

This is also the strongest defense against reading as generic AI-assembled content, which is precisely what the Helpful Content system from Section 14 targets.

Expertise: make the author real

Named authors with real credentials. A byline that links to a genuine bio, not "Admin" and not "The Marketing Team".

Author bio pages that state qualifications, experience, and other places the person has published or spoken.

Consistent identity across the web. The same name, same photo, same bio on LinkedIn, on industry sites, on conference listings. This connects directly to the entity work in Section 40: you are building a person entity, not just a byline.

Person **and** Author **schema** linking the author to their external profiles via sameAs. Section 30 covers the implementation.

For YMYL topics, money or your life, formal credentials matter substantially more. For most commercial topics, demonstrated experience matters more than a certificate.

Authoritativeness: what others say

The hardest to manufacture and largely earned rather than built, which is why Tier 4 exists.

- **Being cited and linked by recognized sources** in your field
- **Brand mentions**, which correlate with AI citation at **0.664** against **0.218** for backlinks [practitioner]
- **Being the recognized source for something specific** rather than vaguely credible about everything, which is the Section 15 topical authority argument again

Trustworthiness: the cheapest wins in the course

Most sites fail trust on things that take an afternoon.

Site-level signals:

- A real **About page** with real people, not stock photos and vague mission language
- **Contact information** that works: address, phone, email, not just a form
- **HTTPS**, which is a confirmed ranking factor and non-negotiable
- **Clear pricing** or an honest explanation of why pricing is bespoke
- **Privacy policy and terms** that exist and are current

- **Real testimonials with real names** and, ideally, verifiable sources

Page-level signals:

- **Sources cited** for factual claims. Section 14 already established that inline citations raise AI citation probability by 30%
- **Publication and update dates** shown honestly
- **Corrections acknowledged** rather than silently edited
- **Balanced coverage**, including limitations of what you sell

That last one is worth dwelling on. A comparison page that says your product wins every category is not credible and readers know it. Saying where a competitor is genuinely better buys more trust than it costs sales.

The honest assessment

Read your most important page and answer:

- 1 Would a stranger know **who wrote this** and why they are worth reading?
- 2 Is there **evidence the author has done this**, not just read about it?
- 3 Are factual claims **sourced**?
- 4 Does the site make it easy to **verify the organization is real**?
- 5 Does the page acknowledge **limitations**, or does it only sell?
- 6 If this page were wrong, would there be a **way to tell**?

Most pages fail three or more of these. Every one is fixable this week.

Why this matters

E-E-A-T is where most sites have the largest gap between how credible they actually are and how credible they look. Agencies with genuine expertise routinely publish anonymous content on sites with no about page. The expertise is real and none of the signals are there.

Do this now

- 1 **Add a named author to your Section 9 page**, with a link to a real bio.
- 2 **Write or upgrade one author bio page**. Qualifications, experience, links to profiles elsewhere.
- 3 **Add one first-hand detail** to the page that could only come from having done the thing.
- 4 **Source every factual claim** on that page, with an inline citation.
- 5 **Audit your About page**. Real people, real photos, real specifics. Fix it if it is boilerplate.
- 6 **Check your contact information works**. Actually send yourself a message through the form.

- 7 Confirm HTTPS across the whole site**, with no mixed-content warnings.
- 8 Find one place to acknowledge a limitation** honestly, on a page that currently only sells.
- 9 Run the six honest-assessment questions** and write down which you fail.

Capstone step

Your capstone site now has a named author with a real bio, first-hand detail and cited sources on the priority page, a genuine About page, working contact details, and at least one honest acknowledgement of limitations. These are the cheapest credibility gains available anywhere in the course.

Key takeaways

- E-E-A-T is not a score and not a direct ranking factor. It is the quality-rater vocabulary, approximated through measurable signals, with Trust at the centre.
- Experience is the one most sites fail. Demonstrate it with what actually happened, your own numbers, named tools, and what you would do differently.
- Expertise means a real named author with a real bio and a consistent identity across the web, which feeds directly into the entity work in Tier 4.
- Trust signals are the cheapest wins in the course: About page, working contact details, HTTPS, cited sources, and honest acknowledgement of limitations.